

Journal Article Review

Social-Emotional Learning, Classroom Climate, and Inclusive Design

An Evidence-Based Reflection on the RULER Approach to SEL

From Individual Skill-Building to Environment-Level Change

Examining how a randomized controlled trial on the RULER SEL approach connects to inclusive, neurodiversity-affirming, and trauma-responsive classroom practice—and to my own lived experience as a Dominican immigrant navigating ADHD, chronic illness, and neurodivergence in educational systems.

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Assignment Journal Article Review — SEL / PBIS

Course ED452C — Instructional Strategies for Inclusive Classrooms

Focus Social-emotional learning as an inclusive, environment-level intervention for neurodivergent, CLD, chronically ill, and multiply identified students

Lens Puzzle Plan & EQUITAS; equity-centered, neurodiversity-affirming practice

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Joy-oriented literacy is not extra. It is part of access. When students feel capable, connected, and allowed to participate as themselves, literacy becomes a tool for liberation, self-determination, and empowerment.

This journal article review examines Rivers, Brackett, Reyes, Elbertson, and Salovey (2013), an empirical clustered randomized controlled trial published in *Prevention Science* testing the RULER Approach to social-emotional learning (SEL) in upper-elementary classrooms across a large urban district. RULER classrooms showed significantly warmer teacher–student relationships, greater student autonomy, and stronger teacher responsiveness to student interests than control classrooms. I summarize the study’s methods, findings, and implications, then reflect on what the evidence means for inclusive classrooms serving neurodivergent, culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD), chronically ill, trauma-experienced, and multiply identified students. I read these findings through two personal lenses: the **Puzzle Plan**, my lesson-design framework for treating each instructional choice as an intentional piece of an inclusive learning environment; and **EQUITAS**, my equity-check framework for asking whether systems create fair, culturally responsive pathways for students to access learning and demonstrate competence. From those lenses, RULER matters because SEL functions as an environment-level intervention that reshapes classroom climate, belonging, equity, and access.

Guiding Claim

Rivers et al. (2013) show that social-emotional learning is not only individual skill instruction; when implemented well, SEL can redesign the relational climate of a classroom. This connects directly to my Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS frameworks because both focus on whether learning environments create fair, responsive, and accessible pathways for students who are neurodivergent, chronically ill, trauma-experienced, culturally and linguistically diverse, or multiply identified.

Summary of Key Information

Rivers et al. (2013) conducted an empirical clustered randomized controlled trial to examine whether the RULER Approach improved the social and emotional climate of upper-elementary classrooms in a large urban district. RULER is a school-based SEL approach that helps teachers integrate emotional recognition, understanding, labeling, expression, and regulation into daily academic instruction. The study included 62 schools randomly assigned either to implement RULER in fifth- and sixth-grade English language arts classrooms or to continue standard classroom practice. Because students were nested within classrooms and schools, the authors used hierarchical linear modeling to estimate program effects while accounting for the structure of the data. Trained observers, who were blind to classroom condition, rated classroom climate using measures of teacher–student warmth, student autonomy and leadership, student–student connection, and teacher responsiveness to student interests. The findings showed that RULER classrooms had significantly stronger social and emotional climates than comparison classrooms. Teachers in RULER classrooms demonstrated warmer relationships with students, provided more opportunities for student autonomy and leadership, and showed greater responsiveness to student motivation and interests (Rivers et al., 2013). The study demonstrates that SEL can produce observable changes in classroom relationships and instructional climate, not merely changes in how teachers or students describe their feelings. In that sense, RULER functions as an environment-level intervention: it changes the conditions under which students participate, ask for help, take risks, and experience belonging.

What I Learned and Why It Matters

This article shifted my understanding of SEL from a lesson-delivery model to a climate-design model. RULER did not simply teach students about emotions; it changed what the classroom felt and functioned like by strengthening teacher–student warmth, student autonomy, and teacher responsiveness to student interests (Rivers et al., 2013). That finding connects directly to the Puzzle Plan’s core principle that an environment is the intervention, and to EQUITAS’s central question: whether a system creates fair, responsive pathways for students to access learning without first having to perform normalcy. The most important thing I learned is that SEL should be understood as access, not just wellness. For students with ADHD, anxiety, depression, autism, chronic illness, trauma histories, or complex intersecting identities, the emotional climate of a classroom can determine whether learning feels possible. My own academic struggles were not failures of motivation; they were often failures of environment. Rigid assessment structures, unclear expectations, and limited flexibility turned competence into collapse. From that perspective, RULER’s focus on warmth, emotional language, and responsiveness functions like Universal Design for Learning: it lowers the emotional and cognitive cost of participation before students reach a breaking point. The study also helped me see that SEL and disability support should not operate as separate systems. When emotional language, student voice, autonomy, and responsive relationships are built into ordinary instruction, support becomes less stigmatizing. A student who can say, “I am overwhelmed,” “I need clarification,” or “I need a different way to participate” is practicing self-advocacy in a real classroom context. That matters for transition readiness as well, because students who experience co-regulation, warm correction, and responsive adult relationships are more prepared to ask for accommodations in college, work, and community life. Overall, Rivers et al. (2013) gave me the language for the difference between a school that accommodates disability and a school that designs for it. Accommodation is reactive; design is proactive. SEL, when implemented at the classroom-climate level, is one evidence-based way to make inclusive design visible in everyday practice.

References

- Rivers, S. E., Brackett, M. A., Reyes, M. R., Elbertson, N. A., & Salovey, P. (2013). Improving the social and emotional climate of classrooms: A clustered randomized controlled trial testing the RULER approach. *Prevention Science, 14*(1), 77–87. doi: 10.1007/s11121-012-0305-2